# Ida Mae Cole Takes a Stance

## By Lynne Nottage

*Ida Mae Cole stands at the bus stop counting the change in her purse. She snaps her gum furiously then sucks her teeth when she realizes that she is twenty-five cents short. Ida stops abruptly to gave at the passersby, cutting her eyes as she meets unwelcome stares. Her clothing is overstated, though clearly color coordinated.*

## INTRODUCTION

*Do you think black women have attitude problems? I know everyone has their "bad" days . . . but I've been studying behavior and body language of black women at home, at school, on the bus, wherever (including myself). And I have noticed a lot of "us" have some attitude problems. It might not be on an everyday basis. Sometimes it's there for a second and gone the next. Case in point . . .Ida Mae Cole.*

*No, I won't tell you about her. I'll show you. After all body language is the single most powerful form of communication. More than voice or even words, nonverbal communication cues you in to what's on another person's mind. Ida Mae Cole Takes a Stance by Lynne Nottage.*

**IDA:** Go on look! Go on! Does anybody know if this is the bus that go downtown, 'cause if it is I need another quarter. Anybody got an extra quarter? Well? WELL? CAN'T ANYBODY HEAR ME?

I'm one of those loud-speaking women you always fear on the bus… The women you walk around and say excuse me to at least three times… I dare any of you to tell me otherwise… Yeah! 'cause you see… I'm the loud-speaking woman who pushes her way forward and always grabs the last potato… peel it, slice it and eat it right there so that everybody knows that it's mine… Ain't no trace of attitude here, 'cause attitude is passé. What I got is

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*Posture!* Punctuated! Assume… Numero Uno. Head cocked, eyebrows arched, lips pursed, hand on hip, finger pointed and a waving. This is the tell me why I was docked a days' pay for coming in an hour late 'cause my daughter had a fever. This is the get off my stoop and go on home position. This is the try me stance, the tell me stance, the why don't you take your fingers off me stance.

Lawd, I stepped on into this posture just the other day. I'd pulled number twelve down at the health clinic, and then had to wait eight hours for the doctor to tell me he… ain't… gonna… see… me… Well, I marched on in his office, I stripped down to the paper robe, oh yes, which covered everything but the bootie. MMM! … You have to leave, he said like he'd just been served the last pig's foot in the jar, and you know how that taste after it been sitting in the sun for a few months. Try me! I said… And he did, he *tried* me … And you know what happened … I GOT EXAMINED! The first time in four years, too, and waited eight hours for the doctor to feel my ti… toddlytutus and ask me how come I hadn't come in sooner, sooner? Sooner! Only day off in the last year and he's going to ask me how come I didn't come in sooner … Shoot …

Posture number two. Legs spread, smile taut, head swaying … The go 'head ask me girl, I won't tell. The oh really, the oh no, oh but it ain't true that he wears her panties beneath his suit. That's what I told her, least five times that he was no good, 'cause I know his type. He gonna make you clean up, then won't show. He gonna make you full up, then won't stay, make you pay

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out, then won't go. And I know what I'm talking about 'cause if you shift the posture on just one foot it becomes a welcoming posture, a thank you posture, the yes I will marry you, the no, I love only you … The where were you, the what do you want looking at me that way? I need you, I'm sorry, I'm here stance … The one that receives the drunken blows and the casual insults, that took an extra shift in the factory to pay for his new suede coat from Vim's, that prayed the siren wasn't going to bring me no bad news about my child, that … Shucks … that don't forget, no punctuation needed …

Not even that time on the bus when … when … I turned my head, and here comes one of them big-thighen women traveling in my direction, and I'm not in the mood to move … bump! She slaps one of her thighs up against mine and the vibration sends a tremor on through my body. Excuse me! We say in unison. I strike posture number one. She don't move. I don't move. Her finger starts waving, my finger starts a waving. Her head starts a moving, my head starts a moving. *You going to let me by?* She says, deep like Barry White. No place to go! I say smooth like Anita Baker. I eased on into posture number two to let her know I'm flexible.

Then she had the nerve to pull a posture on me I'd never seen before. So I tried all variations. And she kept throwing them back at me. We locked eyes, and I thought oh lawd we're gonna throw down right here on the bus heading out to Kings Highway. Then I saw in her eyes the night she'd gotten drunk, the vacationless year, the death of her youngest child, the mammogram results she hadn't told anybody about, and the new suede coat

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she bought at VIM'S for her man … I turned away quick, if we didn't have the same posture, if we didn't. I took two steps to the side, and said GO ON SISTER! GO ON! And that big-thighed sister shoved on down to the back, until she disappeared behind a bus full of attitude.

And it all leads to head tilted, muscles relaxed, arms crossed and feet firmly planted, this is the *just so* position. It's the just so position you see on the bus …

Yes, I'm the loud-speaking woman you avoid on the bus, with the steadfast posture you can't get around. Anyone got a quarter? I don't have enough change. I said does anybody got a quarter?

## SOURCE INFORMATION

***Author: Lynne Nottage***
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